

Porta-bi-li-ty, spelt you-ess-bee

Slow uploads? No problem...Thumbs up to thumb drives

My eyes open slowly. There's a smell and chill in the air that only happens every morning at exactly 7:13. I love waking up to the sounds of birds chirping outside my window, and feel the sun shining on my face, diffused through the light cloud cover. As my senses flow back into me slowly, the day seems full of promise!

BRRRING, BRRING, BRRRRRING, screams my battered, old MTNL phone. AARGH! What an ugly ending to such a beautiful start! BRRRING, BRRRING, BRR... 'Oh shut up already!' I scream, as I snatch at the receiver.

"Hello? Oh good morning sir. No, no, I wasn't asleep...I was, err...actually just about to start on some research for the project. Yes sir, on Monday it will be on your table. Now? No sir, no plans for today. Yes sir. I'll see you in the office at 12. All the data? No sir, I can't e-mail it. No, actually I can e-mail it, but uploading 30 MB on my Internet connection would take all day. Yes sir, not a problem. I will find a way to bring the data with me. Yes sir, see you at 12. Bye."

Disgusted for being such a pushover, and a yes-man to boot, I start getting ready. Damn! Another Saturday wasted at work. Now how do I get 30 MB of data from here to office with least effort? Still pondering, I look out of my window, and see the cyber cafe opening shop.

Aha! I pat myself on the back for having been able to save my skin again, and set off for the cafe. My friend owns it—or rather, he is a friend because he owns it, and I just happen to participate in the monthly *Quake III* LAN parties. He has a thumb drive that will hold my darned 30 MB of data.



Mahesh Benkar

At home, it takes no time to transfer the data onto the thumb drive. These solid state devices have such high read-and write-speeds, I decided to get one for myself! After my meeting, or should I say

bottom-kissing session, my boss told me even he wanted one.

So I stopped by Lamington Road to get a feeler for the prices. The first shop was an authorised dealer for Transcend; Rs 2,050 for a 128 MB drive and Rs 4,250 for 256 MB. "Anything else?" I ask. He promptly pulls out a Samsung, a Billionton and a Lexan. I'd never heard of the last two, and was told that these are little-known Taiwanese brands. "The Samsungs are cheap (Rs 1,800 for 128 MB and Rs 4,000 for 256 MB), but are infamous. The other two are for low budget users, but not recommended," said the dealer. The Billionton would cost Rs 2,350 and Rs 3,500, and the Lexan would set me back by Rs 2,000 and Rs 3,250 for the 128 MB and 256 MB varieties, respectively. Impressed by his honesty, but depressed by his prices, I moved on.

The second guy I went to, had the same Samsung drives for just Rs 1,600 (128 MB) and Rs 3,400 (256 MB). He also had the Transcends for Rs 2,000 and 3,500. I feigned disinterest, so he promptly whipped out a credit-card-sized external hard drive. This USB 2.0 baby would cost me Rs 8,000, and hold 20 GB. I borrowed his calculator to work out the cost per MB ratio—Rs 2.56 per MB.

He also showed me another device from Xtec, which could hold 40 GB of data for just Rs 7,000. He told me that Transcend was also releasing a 40 GB model, but it would take a couple of months and cost a lot more. When I called my boss to tell him this, he was elated, but asked me to get it for less. Typical!

At last I settled on the product, so finding the best deal wasn't that hard. After browsing through four or five shops, I walked into a small dirty-looking store that was selling the Xtec. He wanted Rs 5,000 for the 20 GB and Rs 6,700 for the 40 GB. Well, all I could bring him down to was Rs 6,400 for the 40 GB, and Rs 2,500 for the Samsung 256 MB. I ended up buying the latter.

At least my boss was happy, and I don't have to sit around a cyber cafe waiting for slow uploads to complete. ■



BUYING TIPS

- Look for security features such as read-and-write switches, biometric identification, or at least, software-based security features.
- The drive should have a key ring, or a hook to attach to a cord, for easy portability.
- Data transfer speeds vary! Check this before anything else.
- Cost per MB is a good way to decide between smaller thumb drives and the larger external hard drives.